Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

Privacy Configuration Guide

Privacy thresholds, exclusion lists, data residency & compliance controls

Document Property	Value
Layer	2 — Setup
Audience	IT Admin / Governance
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How This Document Fits

This is a **Layer 2 — Setup** document. It covers the privacy and compliance settings that govern how Copilot Analytics data is collected, stored, and displayed. Configure these settings *before* enabling dashboards or running queries.

Layer	Purpose	Who Reads
1 — Strategy	Decide what to implement	CIO, SA, Business Leaders
2 — Setup (you are here)	Configure and deploy	IT Admin, Insights Admin
3 — Operate	Use dashboards and reports daily	Leaders, Analysts, Managers
4 — Reference	Look up details and fix issues	Everyone (as needed)

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1. Privacy Thresholds

Privacy thresholds ensure that no individual user's behaviour is identifiable in aggregated results. Any group below the configured minimum has its data suppressed entirely.

Setting	Default	Configurable Range
Minimum group size	10 users	5–unlimited (lowest allowed = 5)

How Thresholds Work

- **Data suppression:** Results for groups below the threshold are suppressed — they show as blank or "insufficient data" rather than displaying potentially identifiable information.
- **No individual visibility:** No individual user behaviour is ever visible in the Copilot Dashboard, Power BI reports, or query results.
- **Differential privacy:** Automatically applied to aggregated results. Small amounts of statistical noise are added so that any single person's data cannot be reverse-engineered from the output.
- **Distribution masking:** Hides results where "almost all" or "almost none" of the users fit a particular profile, preventing inference about individuals in near-unanimous groups.

> **Minimum Team Size vs Minimum Group Size — They Are Different**
>
> These two settings apply in different contexts and are configured in different places. Both have a minimum of 5.
>
> | Setting | Where Configured | What It Controls |
> |---|---|---|
> | **Minimum team size** | Viva Insights → Admin → **Manager settings** | Manager-facing insights (My Team tab, Copilo |
> | **Minimum group size** | Viva Insights → Admin → **Privacy settings** | Copilot Dashboard aggregated views, Power E |
>
> **Example:** If both are set to 5, a manager with exactly 4 direct reports will see their team data (4 reports + 1 manager = 5, meeting the team size threshold), but an analyst filtering a dashboard to a group of 4 users will see suppressed data (4 < 5, below the group size threshold).

2. Exclusion Lists

Exclusion lists remove specific users from all Copilot Analytics and Viva Insights reporting. Excluded users' activity data is not collected, processed, or displayed anywhere.

What Gets Excluded

- Copilot Dashboard — excluded users do not appear in any dashboard metric
- Viva Insights behavioural reports (collaboration hours, meeting patterns, etc.)
- M365 Copilot Chat (web) usage data
- Advanced Analytics query results (Power BI person queries, meeting queries, etc.)

How to Upload

Method	Steps
CSV upload	Prepare a CSV with user email addresses → Viva Insights web app → Admin → Privacy settings →
Entra ID groups	Create or select an Entra security group containing users to exclude → Viva Insights web app → A

Processing Times

Action	Time to Take Effect
Adding users to exclusion list	Up to **5 days**
Removing users from exclusion list	Up to **3 days**

> **Plan Exclusions Before Dashboard Launch**
>
> Because exclusions take up to 5 days to apply, configure your exclusion lists **before** enabling the Copilot Dashboard (VFAM). This avoids a window where excluded users' data briefly appears in reports.

3. Data Residency

Copilot Analytics data is processed and stored in the **same geographic region** as your Microsoft 365 tenant. No additional configuration is required for data residency — it follows your tenant's existing data location settings.

Verification Steps

1. Go to **M365 Admin Centre → Settings → Org settings → Organization profile → Data location**.
2. Confirm the listed region meets your compliance and regulatory requirements.
3. If your organisation has specific data sovereignty requirements, consult your compliance team to verify that the tenant region satisfies them.

4. GDPR and Regional Compliance

Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics is designed with GDPR compliance in mind. The following controls support regulatory requirements:

- **User opt-out:** Individual users can opt out of Viva Insights personal experiences via their settings. Exclusion lists (Section 2) provide admin-level opt-out for organisational compliance.
- **Data minimisation:** Only aggregated, de-identified data is surfaced in dashboards and reports. Differential privacy and distribution masking (Section 1) further protect individual data.
- **Org data handling:** If you upload organisational data (CSV with attributes like Department, Agency, Location), ensure the upload process follows your organisation's data handling policies. Do not include sensitive personal data in org data attributes.
- **Data subject requests:** Standard Microsoft 365 Data Subject Request (DSR) tools apply to Viva Insights data. Use the M365 Admin Centre to process access, export, or deletion requests.

> **Regional Considerations**
>
> Some regions may have additional requirements beyond GDPR (e.g., UK-GDPR, Australia Privacy Act). Work with your legal and compliance teams to confirm that your privacy threshold settings, exclusion lists, and org data handling meet local regulations.

5. Data Retention

Different analytics surfaces retain data for different periods. Plan your reporting cadence accordingly — if you need long-term trends, use Advanced Analytics with Power BI snapshots.

Data Source	Retention Period	Notes
Admin Centre Reports	Up to **180 days**	M365 Admin Centre → Reports → Usage
Copilot Dashboard	**28-day** rolling window	Always shows the most recent 28 days; no h
Advanced Analytics — Collaboration metrics	Up to **27 months**	Starts at 13 months; grows weekly as data a
Advanced Analytics — Copilot metrics	Up to **13 months**	Copilot-specific metrics (Assisted Hours, ac

Monthly Snapshots for Long-Term Trends

The Copilot Dashboard's 28-day rolling window means historical data is not preserved. To track trends over time, schedule monthly Power BI report refreshes and save snapshots. See the Analyst Playbook for snapshot scheduling guidance.

6. What to Read Next

Document	When to Use
Admin Setup Guide	Configure all five analytics tiers — roles, licences, VFAM, org data, and partitions
Troubleshooting Guide	Fix common issues: missing data, dashboard not appearing, suppressed metrics
Data Onboarding Guide	Upload and validate organisational data (CSV attributes, Entra sync)
Dashboard Guide	Understand each dashboard page and how to interpret the metrics

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